

Cybersecurity for SME Employees

Module 3.4 – Practical Scenarios: Spot the Scam

1 Objective

Train employees to identify suspicious elements in real-world cyberattack scenarios by analyzing common red flags and applying knowledge from previous modules.

2 Introduction

Understanding theory is one thing—applying it is another. This module presents practical scenarios that mimic real phishing and social engineering attacks. The goal is to sharpen your instincts and build confidence in spotting threats.

3 Scenario 1: The Suspicious HR Email

Subject: Salary Adjustment Notification

Message: “Dear Employee, due to recent budget updates, your new salary has been recalculated. Please login here hr-portal-updates.com to review your new compensation.”

Red Flags:

- Unfamiliar link not related to official HR domain.
- Generic greeting – no name used.
- Sense of urgency around personal financial info.

Correct Action: Do not click the link. Report the email and verify with HR through known contact channels.

4 Scenario 2: The Urgent Vendor Request

Email: “Hi, this is Asha from [Trusted Vendor]. We’ve updated our bank account. Please ensure that future payments go to this new account: [details].”

Red Flags:

- Unexpected financial change with no prior discussion.
- Requesting sensitive transaction outside secure vendor portal.
- Pressure to act quickly.

Correct Action: Call the vendor using a known phone number to confirm. Report the email as suspicious.

5 Scenario 3: USB Drop Attack

You find a USB drive labeled “Confidential Staff Salary” in the office parking lot.

Red Flags:

- Unattended USB could be bait with malware.
- Label plays on curiosity and relevance.

Correct Action: Do not plug it into any device. Submit it to IT/security immediately.

6 Scenario 4: Fake CEO Request

Email: “I’m on a flight and need you to urgently wire \$5,000 to this account. Will explain later. Please confirm once done. — Sent from iPhone”

Red Flags:

- Urgency and vagueness.
- Unusual request breaking payment procedures.
- Impersonation of executive.

Correct Action: Verify directly using alternate contact methods. Don’t act without confirmation.

7 Tips for Spotting Scams in Any Format

- Always check sender identity and domain names.
- Be cautious with urgent language and requests for secrecy.
- Don’t trust links or attachments unless expected.
- Report anything suspicious—better safe than sorry.

8 Conclusion

The more you practice spotting scams, the better you become at it. Trust your instincts, pause before acting, and always verify. In the next module, we’ll cover what to do if you accidentally fall for a scam—and how to limit the damage quickly.